

Action Plan Supporting CoARA 2024

Preamble

Taighde Éireann – Research Ireland (Research Ireland) is the new national research and innovation (R&I) funding agency, established through the amalgamation of the activities and functions of Science Foundation Ireland (SFI) and the Irish Research Council (IRC). Whilst the Action Plan Supporting CoARA 2024 reflects a consolidated position, the intent is to adopt a more harmonised approach as the new agency matures and adopts its new corporate plan to reflect the legislative position upon which it has been established¹.

All functions and agreements attributed to the two legacy organisations have transferred over to Research Ireland as of 1 August 2024. With reference to the commitments made by the legacy organisations, Research Ireland is a member of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) and remains committed to contributing to and promoting the objectives of the Coalition and helping to advance the reform of research assessment (RRA) in the Irish Research and Innovation ecosystem, as demonstrated through the actions described in this plan.

About Research Ireland

Research Ireland is a new, competitive research and innovation funding agency in Ireland. The establishment of the agency was a key action of *Impact 2030: Ireland's Research and Innovation Strategy*². Research Ireland was established on 1st August 2024, following an amalgamation of Science Foundation Ireland (SFI) and the Irish Research Council (IRC).

Research Ireland is an agency of the Department of Further and Higher Education, Research Innovation and Science (DFHERIS) working in collaboration with higher education institutions and other state agencies such as the Higher Education Authority (HEA), IDA Ireland, and Enterprise Ireland.

¹ [Research and Innovation Act 2024](#)

² [Impact 2030: Ireland's Research and Innovation Strategy](#)

The Objectives of Research Ireland, as set out in the Research and Innovation Bill 2024 are to:

- Promote the attainment and maintenance of excellence in the standard and quality of research and innovation.
- Support the undertaking of research and innovation in all fields of activity and disciplines by researchers with different levels of knowledge, experience and specialist skills in such fields or disciplines.
- Promote and support the contribution made by research and innovation to economic, social, cultural, and environmental development and sustainability in the State.
- Strengthen the engagement of the research and innovation system with:
 - the Government, Ministers of the Government and bodies (whether statutory or otherwise) which are funded wholly or partly by public moneys, and
 - enterprise, non-governmental organisations, cultural institutions and society generally; to promote and develop the reputation of the State internationally as a location that is favourable for undertaking research and innovation; to advance the principles of equality, diversity and inclusion with regard to opportunities to undertake research and innovation and in the undertaking of that research and innovation.

Action Plan Context

Research assessment is central to Research Ireland's activities in supporting programmes of research and innovation, and education and public engagement which are both excellent and impactful. Research Ireland is guided by a number of organisational and national strategies which inform the Organisation's activities in this regard:

- [Impact 2030: Ireland's Research and Innovation Strategy](#)
- [Research Ireland's External Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion \(EDI\) Strategy 2023-2028](#)
- [Higher Education Authority Act 2022](#)
- [Researcher Career Development Framework | Irish Universities Association](#)

Involvement of the research community

Research Ireland continuously reviews its processes and policies through iterative national and international stakeholder engagement, reflecting its commitment to improving all dimensions of research culture, including Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI). The organisation works closely with the Research Offices of the Higher Education Institutions, applicants, grant holders, and reviewers to ensure that Research Ireland effectively supports and serves the R&I sector in Ireland.

Furthermore, Research Ireland undertakes consultation with stakeholders beyond its traditional community, including representatives of Historically Underserved Communities, to understand the diversity of the research community in Ireland and craft interventions in RRA that are actionable, impactful, and can provide the results anticipated. Research Ireland is also represented on a number of CoARA Working Groups, including the CoARA National Chapter for Ireland, providing the agency with diverse opportunities for innovation, consultation, and collaboration in the space of RRA.

Key Challenges and Opportunities

As a new organisation, Research Ireland has identified a number of challenges and opportunities in the RRA space, building upon the journeys of the historic agencies and with reference to the new legislation upon which it has been established. Therefore, the actions detailed in the below table have been considered in these contexts and its broad remit to fund across all disciplines. The actions speak to the commitments, engagements, and progress with RRA attributed to both historic agencies.

It is anticipated that these actions will be revisited during 2025 to ensure they are fit for purpose in the context of supporting the organisation's remit, as well as the entire research community in Ireland.

A challenge concerns the effort and time burden placed on the individuals involved in the various CoARA working groups and forums on which Research Ireland sits, as well as those agency staff who directly manage research assessment processes for programme calls, including expert reviewer selection and review panel formation. Meaningful contributions to the multiple CoARA working groups with which Research Ireland is associated require contributing to the formation of a broad scientific evidence base and review of international best practice in RRA, the potential running of proposed pilots in Research Ireland programme calls, and extensive stakeholder consultation. Since the actions described below in supporting RRA will evolve, further resources will be required to effectively and efficiently implement changes in the organisation's processes and policies, in line with Research Ireland's commitments to CoARA and related initiatives such as the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA).³

³ <https://sfdora.org/>

The following table details Research Ireland's planned actions according to the commitments of the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment

	Commitment	Examples of tools to support this commitment/options to consider	Actions as of November 2024
1	Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	Enable greater diversity in career paths and profiles by recognising more diverse competencies and talents⁴ Use approaches that allow academics to make a mark in one or more key areas of study that are important to them, and allow their area profile to change over the course of their career⁵ Use a portfolio approach to test competencies or progression in different domains relevant to the researcher's role⁶	For boxes 1-4: Research Ireland continues to participate in and contribute to relevant forums and working groups on the reform of research assessment (RRA), supporting its commitments to DORA and CoARA. These groups include: - The Global Research Council Working Group on Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion - The DORA Funders Forum - The CoARA Working Group on Experiments in Assessment - The CoARA Working Group on Improving practices in the assessment of research proposals - GENDERACTIONPlus Research Funding Organisation (RFO) Community of Practice.
2	Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of	Consider specific actions captured under the Leiden Manifesto⁷ Explore options for assessment; as a rule of thumb, use quantitative indicators for quantitative things (if that is what is appropriate to assess): publications, funding, citations and	

⁴ <https://www.universiteitenvannederland.nl/recognitionandrewards/wp-content/uploads/2019/11/Position-paper-Room-for-everyone%E2%80%99s-talent.pdf>

⁵ <https://www.universiteitenvannederland.nl/recognitionandrewards/wp-content/uploads/2019/11/Position-paperRoom-for-everyone%E2%80%99s-talent.pdf>

⁶ <https://embassy.science/wiki/Resource:Ca0ed587-ac8e-4259-9cc7-74de01941cd1>; <https://assets-eu-01.kc-usercontent.com/546dd520-97db-01b7-154d-79bb6d950a2d/6eb2e1cc-068a-4283-b6dea281868b749d/Qualification-portfolio-professors-UMC%20Utrecht.pdf>

⁷ <https://doi.org/10.1038/520429a>

	quantitative indicators	students, and qualitative indicators (such as case studies, narratives or statements) for qualitative things: excellence, quality, value, impact, and be very cautious about using quantitative indicators for qualitative things⁸ Actively engage in and learn from ‘research on research-work’ to develop new improved metrics, and consider appropriateness of their use	Challenges and opportunities to RRA will continue to be discussed and initiatives and/or innovations will be implemented in Research Ireland funding programmes and research policies as relevant and appropriate. Guidance and templates relating to the Research Ireland Narrative CV will continue to be informed and strengthened by these groups, as well as iterative consultation with the research community, including Early-Career Researchers. A Narrative CV template for large-scale, team-based grants will continue to be developed and implemented on research programmes where relevant. A variant of the Narrative CV is deployed in some programmes including in early career researcher programme calls which encourage applicants to ‘tell the story’ of their research/take a narrative approach in describing their research achievements and impact. In addition, these programmes apply gender blind peer review and extensions to eligibility windows to account for eligible career breaks/leave
3	Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h- index	Consider specific actions described in the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA)⁹ and the Leiden Manifesto¹⁰	
4	Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	Consider specific actions described in the INORMS¹¹ tools for rethinking global university rankings Consider the recommendations in the Metric Tide report¹²	

⁸ <https://thebibliomagician.wordpress.com/2019/12/11/introducing-scope-a-process-for-evaluating-responsibly/>

⁹ <https://sfdora.org/read/>

¹⁰ <https://doi.org/10.1038/520429a>

¹¹ <https://inorms.net/wp-content/uploads/2022/07/principles-for-fair-and-responsible-university-assessment-v5.pdf>

¹² <https://doi.org/10.13140/RG.2.1.4929.1363>

			The Research Ireland Narrative CV does not permit the inclusion of most journal-and publication-based indicators, in line with DORA guidance and principles. Where relevant, Research Ireland advise applicants that, if these indicators are included, they may be redacted prior to expert review. Research Ireland will explore further methods for discouraging the inclusion of inappropriate journal-and publication-based indicators in submitted Narrative CVs and proposals more broadly. Guidance and resources for reviewers on the evaluation of narrative-style CVs including evaluation of qualitative measures of research achievement and impact will continue to be developed and strengthened. This guidance will be informed by consultation and feedback from the research community, DORA resources, and the CoARA National Chapter (Ireland). Research Ireland will aim to incorporate changes to midterm and annual review processes to align with the Leiden Manifesto, DORA principles, and CoARA commitments. This includes the evaluation of progress made against the Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI) Action Plans on relevant programmes, and the expansion of a qualitative,
--	--	--	---

			narrative-style reporting template for grant holders will be explored.
5	Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to		Research Ireland has dedicated resources to support its initiatives to advance the RRA, including its commitments to CoARA and DORA. One team member co-manages Research Ireland's commitments to CoARA, including the agency's representation to the CoARA Experiments in Assessment Working Group and the Improving practices in the assessment of research proposals working group. A second team member manages Research Ireland's External EDI Strategy, co-manages Research Ireland's representation on the CoARA Experiments in Assessment Working Group, the CoARA National Chapter, and leads on Research Ireland's commitments to DORA and the implementation of the Narrative CV. Further staff represent the organisation on the GENDERACTIONplus RFO CoP Working group on 'Bias in the Evaluation Process', for which Research Ireland is the lead agency. The Agency is also a member of the ESVH (Ending Sexual Violence in Higher Education) Advisory Group.

			Further Research Ireland resources will be required to progress RRA due to the increased policy and programmatic brief associated with harmonisation of the approaches of the legacy agencies within the newly established entity and to advance commitments to CoARA and DORA.
6	Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes		The RRA underpins several of the key objectives and actions of the Research Ireland External Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI) Strategy 2023-2028.¹³ Research Ireland has implemented several initiatives in relevant policies and research programme calls to further RRA. These include a gender (binary) tiebreak criterion in several research programme calls whereby in the event of applications receiving the same final score, Research Ireland gives priority in the review process to applications from woman lead applicants. Targeted recruitment of early-career applicants through incentive schemes for host research organisations was implemented and resulted in increased gender (binary) balance amongst applicants and grant holders. Research Ireland is implementing an EDI Action Plan on select research funding programmes awarding

¹³ <https://www.sfi.ie/funding/sfi-policies-and-guidance/gender/SFI-External-Equality-Diversity-and-Inclusion-Strategy-2023-2028.pdf>

			grants of scale that is a scored, evaluation criterion in the review process. It is intended that the strength of an EDI plan will serve as a tiebreaker with applications submitted under competitive funding programmes awarding grants of scale if two applications receive the same score during the review process. Research Ireland continues to operate a minimum 40% policy in relation to assessment panels (including sitting panels), whereby we strive to ensure that there is no less than 40% women or men. Research Ireland will undertake a review of the reviewer selection process to ensure that invited expert reviewers meet minimum diversity requirements, including a demonstrable increase in reviewers from Historically Underserved Communities.
7	Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria	Host webinars to inform applicants of assessment processes and allow for questions and answers Provide training, guidance and support to assessment panels, committees and juries	Box 7,8 and 9 merged responses. We are in iterative consultation with the research community concerning our RRA initiatives such as Narrative CV guidance. Research Ireland is active in the CoARA National Chapter, which serves as a

	and processes as well as their use	Publish webpages and reports to communicate the transparency of research evaluation processes¹⁴ Ensure transparency of research assessment processes - good examples for promoting transparency include: strict conflict-of-interest regulations, applicant right-to-reply procedures, and open (non-anonymous) reviewing¹⁵	sounding board for our RRA initiatives to ensure they are implementable by the community. Research Ireland strives to regularly update the community on progress against its commitments and relevant strategies.
8	Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	Build national assessment consortia, consider existing national consortia for reforming responsible assessment: in Finland¹⁶, Norway¹⁷, and the Netherlands¹⁸ Foster an international debate on recognition and rewards	
9	Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments		

¹⁴ <https://www.scienceeurope.org/our-priorities/research-assessment/research-assessment-processes/>

¹⁵ <https://www.scienceeurope.org/our-priorities/research-assessment/research-assessment-processes/>

¹⁶ <https://doi.org/10.23847/isbn.9789525995282>

¹⁷ <https://www.uhr.no/en/front-page-carousel/nor-cam-a-toolbox-for-recognition-and-rewards-in-academiccareers.5780.aspx>

¹⁸ <https://recognitionrewards.nl/>

10	Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research		Research Ireland (as its former constituent entity, SFI) was a cooperating Research Funding Organisation (RFO) on the Horizon 2020 project, GRANteD – Grant Allocation Disparities from a gender perspective¹⁹. Based on empirical evidence, GRANteD aims to review the occurrence and causes of gender bias in research funding in Europe. In the collaboration, the Frontiers for the Future 2020 call was evaluated by international experts in the field of gender equality in research funding. The results that arose from this evaluation provided the Agency with recommendations to consider implementing across its funding programmes which will inform Research Ireland’s RRA and EDI initiatives moving forward. Research Ireland contributed to the advisory board of global evaluation of RFOs integration of sex/gender dimension in research led by Londa Schiebinger.²⁰ The study resulted in concluding that RFOs should work collaboratively to achieve ‘efficient implementations of [sex, gender, and diversity] related funding policies globally, which Research Ireland commits to promoting through its own implementation of the sex & gender dimension in research statement in applications to research grant programmes. Aligning with expert
----	---	--	---

¹⁹ <https://www.granted-project.eu/>

²⁰ <https://alzped.nia.nih.gov/sites/default/files/2022-11/HuntMathias%20et%20al.%2C%20Science%202022.pdf>.

			recommendations and best practice, Research Ireland aims to broaden this out to other areas of social discrimination as part of the implementation of the External EDI Action Strategy and Action Plan. Research Ireland (as its former constituent entity, SFI) had been collecting and analysing data on application submission and success rates by gender (binary) since 2011. These data have enabled it to monitor the effectiveness of its gender redressing initiatives, reveal if there are unintentional gender biases in review processes and examine gender balance across the portfolio of research grants. The Gender Dashboard²¹ presents analyses of gender (binary) disaggregated data across all legacy SFI Funding Programmes from 2011 and is currently being updated to include the expanded gender identifier options now available to Research Ireland applicants, Grant holders, and reviewers on its Grants and Awards Management System, SESAME²². In addition, Research Ireland will lead an action around promoting a positive and safe culture for grant holders and their team members with an aim to review Research Ireland's current policy on bullying, harassment, and sexual violence as it applies to Research Ireland-funded programmes.
--	--	--	---

²¹ <https://www.sfi.ie/funding/sfi-policies-and-guidance/gender/>

²² <https://www.sfi.ie/research-news/news/gender-identifiers/#:~:text=SFI%20applicants%2C%20grant%20holders%2C%20and,Non%2DBinary>

			This will ensure Research Ireland remains aligned with international best practice as formal measures to prevent and mitigate bullying, harassment, and sexual violence are very likely to become a mandatory element of the Gender Equality Plans (GEPs) in the 10th EU Framework Programme for Research and Innovation (FP10).
--	--	--	--

In addition to our activities directly related to research assessment reform and CoARA, Research Ireland promotes other policy initiatives such as Environmental, Sustainability and Governance under our [Climate Action Strategy 2024-2027](#). The strategy outlines the organisation's approach to integrate climate action and sustainability into all our functions - the grants Research Ireland awards, the accessibility of the new knowledge and talent developed, Research Ireland collaborations and Research Ireland's support of research practices.